Watchful Mama Bear Gemini Wins the Helicopter Mom Award

From: Popular Science Mined: 2026-11-03 5 min read

Even bears can be **helicopter** parents. The term, coined in the 1990s by child development researchers Foster Cline and Jim Fay, describes overly cautious parents who constantly monitor, control, and hover over their children's activities out of fear.

For these watchful tendencies, the U.S. Forest Service team at Tongass National Forest in southeastern Alaska has awarded a brown bear named Gemini with the 2026 **Helicopter** Mom Award.

"We understand her choice, weighing the dangers of being around other bears at a prime fishing location," the **rangers** write. "Still, we hope we see a lot more of them next year."

Gemini kept an eye on her cubs around other bears fishing in Alaska's Anan Creek. The numbers also back up Gemini and other mother bears' watchfulness. Brown bear cubs in Alaska have a roughly 50 percent **survival** rate within their first year, while the black bear cub **survival** rate can range from 51 to 88 percent depending on the location. Gemini has also had cubs in 2023 and 2024.

The **rangers** at Tongass National Forest are currently awarding the Anan Bear Awards to the 39 bears spotted at the Anan Wildlife **Observatory** over the summer.

According to Friends of Anan, 39 bears are known to feast on the salmon at Anan Creek. The population includes 31 black bears and eight brown bears. Like their counterparts further north in Katmai National Park, the bears return annually each summer to eat salmon and teach their young how to fish and survive. Every bear here exhibits their own habits and **quirks**.

The U.S. Forest Service tracks and documents every bear, while explore.org's cameras broadcast live streams of their antics.

Word Treasure

helicopter -- Here, a parent who hovers over children all the time, like a helicopter hovering in the air.

observatory -- A place where people watch and study animals or the sky.

survival -- Staying alive, especially in a difficult or dangerous place.

rangers -- People who look after a park or forest and the animals in it.

quirks -- Small, unusual habits that make a person or animal special.

Background you need

A helicopter parent is a parent who watches and controls their children very closely, often because they worry about danger.

Mother bears must protect cubs that are small and vulnerable, especially around other bears at busy fishing spots.

Salmon runs bring many bears to the same creek each summer, giving rangers a chance to watch and name individual bears.

Awards like the Anan Bear Awards are a fun way for rangers to share what they learn about each bear's habits.

Break it down

LEAD: Mama bear Gemini won the 2026 Helicopter Mom Award for watching over her cubs.

KEY EVENT: Rangers at Tongass National Forest gave Gemini the award for her watchfulness at Anan Creek.

+- WHO: Gemini, a brown bear, and her cubs, watched by Forest Service rangers.

+- WHEN: The award is for 2026, after bears were spotted over the summer.

EVIDENCE: Brown bear cubs in Alaska have about a 50 percent first-year survival rate, backing up a mother's watchfulness.

OPEN QUESTION: Rangers hope to see a lot more of Gemini and her cubs next year.

Why it matters

Gemini's story shows why mother animals stay close to their young in the wild, and how rangers learn about bears by watching them summer after summer.

Test what you remember

1. What award did Gemini win?

(A) The Fat Bear Award
(B) The 2026 Helicopter Mom Award
(C) The Best Fisher Award
(D) The Alaska Bear Award

2. Where did Gemini watch over her cubs?

(A) At Mendenhall Glacier
(B) At Anan Creek in Alaska
(C) In Juneau city
(D) At Katmai National Park

3. What is a helicopter parent, according to the article?

(A) An overly cautious parent who constantly monitors and hovers over children
(B) A parent who never watches children
(C) A parent who flies a helicopter
(D) A parent who lives in a forest

4. About what percent of brown bear cubs in Alaska survive their first year?

(A) About 10 percent
(B) About 50 percent
(C) About 90 percent
(D) About 100 percent

5. How many bears were spotted at the Anan Wildlife Observatory over the summer?

(A) 8
(B) 31
(C) 50
(D) 39

6. How many of the Anan Creek bears are brown bears?

(A) 21
(B) 39
(C) 31
(D) Eight

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Tongass National Forest rangers: Say they understand Gemini's choice given dangers around other bears, and hope to see more of them next year.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):